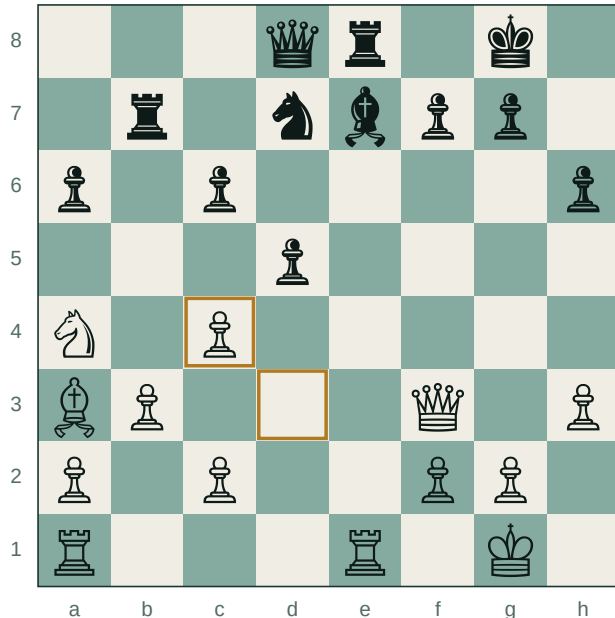


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 19

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 19.dxc4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

19...Bxa3 20. Rxe8+ Qxe8

19...Bxa3 The bishop captures the bishop on a3. The changed line means the rook on e8 attacks the rook on e1.
Recorded reply: **20.Rxe8+**.

20...Qxe8 The queen captures the rook on e8.

At the end, nominal material is White 24 / Black 26 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +3:** the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on a3. Check for tactical protection.